

Building Your Personal AI Workspace



FROM ADHOC TO SYSTEMATIC Part III has covered the building blocks of an AI environment: persistent instructions, projects, document management, tools, and memory. This chapter shows how to put them together into a workspace that reflects how you actually work.

A well-built AI workspace is not a technical achievement. It is a professional one: the result of thinking carefully about what you need AI for, what context it should always have, and how your recurring work is organised.

THE WORKSPACE AUDIT Before building, take stock. Answer these questions:

WHAT DO I USE AI FOR MOST OFTEN? List your five most common AI tasks. These are the tasks your workspace should be optimised for.

WHAT CONTEXT DO I RE-ENTER REPEATEDLY? What information do you find yourself providing in almost every session? This is what should be in your persistent instructions.

WHAT RECURRING PROJECTS OR TASK TYPES DO I HAVE? What work comes around every week, every month, or for every client? Each recurring type deserves its own Project.

WHAT DOCUMENTS DOES AI REGULARLY NEED? What files do you find yourself uploading repeatedly? These belong in the relevant Project.

WHAT ARE MY QUALITY STANDARDS? What makes output unusable for you? What do you always correct? These corrections belong in your persistent instructions as explicit rules.

A COMPLETED WORKSPACE AUDIT Take David's consultancy as an example. His answers produce three workspaces:

Client work: one Project per active client, containing the brief, approved source documents, a tone reference, previous deliverables, and client-specific constraints. Recurring reports: a Project containing the reporting template, a completed example, the standard headings, and the monthly input checklist. Personal practice: a small workspace for prompt experiments, failure notes, and reusable patterns that are not tied to a client.

His persistent instructions hold the information that applies everywhere: his role, UK spelling, plain professional language, and a default instruction to flag unsupported facts. Project instructions hold what changes by client or task. This separation prevents a client-specific constraint from leaking into unrelated work.

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A SIMPLE WORKSPACE STRUCTURE FOR MOST PROFESSIONALS

PERSISTENT INSTRUCTIONS (applies to everything) ■■■ Professional context ■■■ Communication preferences ■■■ Standard audience ■■■ Default behaviours (verification, format, etc.)

PROJECTS ■■■ Project A: [Client / Ongoing work 1] ■ ■■■ Project instructions (context specific to this work) ■ ■■■ Reference documents (brand guide, style reference, etc.) ■ ■■■ Ongoing conversations ■ ■■■ Project B: [Client / Ongoing work 2] ■ ■■■ [Same structure] ■ ■■■ Project C: Recurring tasks ■■■ Weekly report template and example ■■■ Standard document formats ■■■ Template prompts for recurring work

THE RECURRING TASK TEMPLATE For any task you do on a regular cadence, a template prompt is worth building. A template prompt is a prompt with placeholders, variables you update with each use, built on a structure you've already tested and refined.

Format:



[TEMPLATE NAME]

Context (stable): [Everything that stays the same, purpose, audience, style, constraints]

Variable inputs this week: [PASTE CONTENT HERE] [KEY DATES: X] [KEY DECISIONS: X]

Output required: [Format, length, structure, specified once, used every time]



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This reduces a recurring AI task to: open the template, fill in the variables, run. The setup investment is front-loaded; the recurring use is fast.

PRO TIP KEEP A "TEMPLATES" SECTION WITHIN YOUR AI WORKSPACE, EITHER A PROJECT DEDICATED TO THIS, OR A SIMPLE

WORKSPACE MAINTENANCE A workspace that isn't maintained becomes a liability. Outdated context produces confidently wrong outputs. Review your workspace periodically:

Monthly: Are the persistent instructions still accurate? Has anything changed about your role, audience, or constraints? When a project ends: Archive or close the project so it doesn't contaminate future work with irrelevant context. When something keeps going wrong: What's in your workspace that might be causing this? What context might AI be applying incorrectly?

The workspace is a living document of your working relationship with AI, not a one-time setup.

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WATCH OUT WORKSPACES CREATED ON ONE PLATFORM DO NOT TRANSFER TO ANOTHER. YOUR CLAUDE PROJECTS, YOUR

WHAT PART III HAS ESTABLISHED You now have the framework for building an AI environment:

Persistent instructions that carry your context forward automatically Projects that organise your work and maintain document access Document handling practices that maximise accuracy and catch common errors An understanding of tools and their limitations A memory strategy that works across platforms A workspace structure suited to professional use

Part IV moves from individual interactions and workspace setup to something qualitatively different: multi-step workflows that tackle complex tasks by breaking them into stages.



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PART IV From Prompts to Workflows

Complex work doesn't happen in a single exchange. Part IV introduces the thinking and techniques that take AI from answering individual questions to participating in multi-stage processes, planning, drafting, reviewing, revising, and handing off.



IN THIS PART

CHAPTER 16 CHAPTER 17 When One Prompt Isn't Enough Breaking Tasks Into Steps

CHAPTER 18 CHAPTER 19 Critique, Edit, and Improve Chains, Loops, and Handoffs